Call Me Charlie

By Josh Bond

I managed a hotel and an apartment building in Santa Monica for about seven years. I lived in the apartment building and had an office in the hotel across the street. You meet a lot of interesting people when you manage an apartment building. For example, there was a retired couple who lived in the apartment next to mine -- the Gaskos. The first time I met the husband, I was in my apartment playing guitar and trying to write a song. There's a knock on the door, and I open it to find a seventy-year-old man holding a black case. He tells me that he heard me playing music, and he thought I could use this black Stetson cowboy hat. Really nice gesture. I thank him, and he says his name is Charlie.

INTRODUCTION

For well over a decade, Charlie Gasko, better known as James "Whitey" Bulger was America's most wanted gangster—the FBI's biggest domestic target, second in priority only to Osama bin Laden. As a leader of Boston's Winter Hill Gang, Bulger was wanted by the Bureau on 19 charges of murder, as well as for numerous other offenses including racketeering, extortion and narcotics distribution. And yet, for 16 years—from just before Christmas 1994 until June 23, 2011—he remained at large. The main reason Bulger was able to first evade capture was that he had a man on the inside: FBI agent John Connolly. Connolly tipped Bulger off to a secret grand jury indictment, allowing the mobster to flee before his arrest.

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So fast-forward five years. I'm taking a nap on my couch. At 2:00 p.m. the phone rings, and my co-worker is at the hotel with the FBI. Before I know it, I'm on the phone with an FBI agent says, "I need to talk to you about a tenant in your apartment building. Come here now."

So, I get to my office and have a seat, and there's a large man wearing a Hawaiian shirt and jeans. He closes the door, throws a manila folder down on the desk, opens it and points to a sheet of paper. Across the top is "**WANTED** and, underneath, a photo of a man and a woman, with names.

He asks if these people live in the apartment next

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to mine. The woman is my neighbor, Carol Gasko. And while I've never heard the name "Catherine Greig," the name "James J. 'Whitey' Bulger" is very familiar. I had heard this name many times when I was in college at Boston University. But I didn't really know anything about him. He was a Jimmy Hoffa type guy to me, like, "Oh, this guy's missing, he's never gonna be found." It was almost like a joke.

So, I'm standing there, and the FBI agent says, "What do you think?"

"What does my face tell you?"

So, he gets on his radio, and while this is happening, it is almost like in a movie after an explosion where the sound just disappears. You don't know what's going on, and you don't know what's about to happen.

This is an old man who bought me a bike light one time because he was worried about me riding at night without one. And now I'm discovering he's a notorious fugitive?!

Hawaiian Shirt says, "Look, this guy's pretty high on the most-wanted list. We could use your help

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apprehending him. We can't just go to his apartment. We have to make sure he's in there. If it's just her, it doesn't really work for us. So why don't you go knock on the door and see if he's there?"

In the previous months, Carol had been telling people in the building, "Charlie has dementia, he has heart problems." They'd put notes on their door during the day that said, *"Don't knock on the door."* I knew from talking to him over the years that he slept during the day.

I explain this to the agent, and without skipping a beat he says, "Well, what are you doing tonight?" I realize I'm going to be with these guys until they have him in cuffs.

Then things really kick in. They place an agent at a window in the hotel that has a good view of the Gaskos' balcony. Then the agent wants to go to ***my*** apartment. I take him through a back alley and some side streets, so we aren't walking in front of the apartment building in clear view of Charlie and Carol. We're stopping at cars, and he's talking on the

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radio, and there are agents everywhere!

Hawaiian Shirt says, "They just closed their blinds. Did you tip 'em off?"

"I've been with you the whole time, no, ***of course not."***

We get to my apartment, and I draw them a floor plan of the Gaskos' place. We're throwing ideas back and forth about how to get this guy out of his apartment.

My living room wall shares a wall with Charlie's bedroom, so I'm like, "Uh, you know this guy can hear everything we're saying? Like, he's repeated conversations I've had with my friends, asking me why we don't curse or fight as much as he and his friends did in his younger days."

We go into my bedroom, and we come up with an idea. We're going to break into his storage locker in the garage. We go down to the garage, and the FBI agent goes to get his car; he has some bolt cutters in there.

I'm suddenly pumped up. I'm involved in something. It's like a movie. I'm almost having fun at

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this point. The adrenaline is helping me forget about my relationship to these people. I mean, this is the same man who bought me a Christmas present every year.

Once the lock is broken, we go back to my apartment, and the agent's telling me, "Okay, this is what's gonna happen. I'm gonna go down, get everything set, I'm gonna call you, and you knock on his door and bring him down."

And I'm like, "No, I'm going to go to the hotel, I'm going to ***call*** him, tell him to meet me ***there***. Then you guys take care of your business."

I'm in my office, and I'm thinking about this guy, my neighbor, who looked after an old woman on the first floor. Who one year, when I didn't write a thank you note for a Christmas present he gave me, gave me a box of stationery.

I'm thinking, ***What did this guy actually DO?***

So I go to Wikipedia, and I'm reading about murders and extortion and gambling. I get to the bottom, and in one of his last public sightings with one of his Mafia buddies there's a quote from him:

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"When I go down, I'm going out with guns blazing."

I start to rethink my involvement in the day's events. Conveniently, my phone rings, and it's the FBI: "Make the call."

I start to waver: "Look, man, I just read something about this guy. . . and I don't know about this."

He says, "No, no, no, he'll never know, he'll never know." Which is obviously ***not true****.*

But . . . I call the Gaskos from the hotel, and there is no answer. I am so happy that they didn't answer the phone. I call the agent back, and I say, "Hey, man, sorry, they didn't answer. Going to have to do something else."

He says, "Are you *sure* you don't want to knock on the door?"

And I'm like, "Look, man, what if he comes to the door with a gun?"

He says, "Just be like, 'Hey, man, what's going on?' "

I'm thinking to myself, ***Uh, he will shoot me before I finish that one statement.***

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But while this is going on, Carol calls back. I explain to her that the storage unit's been broken into. I can either call the police, or Charlie can meet me in the garage and we'll look at it.

She says, "He'll be down in five minutes."

Hang up, call the FBI. "He's on his way."

******* Looks through curtains at the chaos*******

[The take-down didn't take long] As soon as I open the door, it's like a slow-motion shot of Suburbans and vans and FBI agents everywhere. And my neighbor, Charlie Gasko, standing there in cuffs, surrounded by agents, laughing and telling stories. He almost looks relieved. I see Carol standing a few feet away in cuffs. And the magnitude of everything that has happened starts to sink in. I helped the FBI arrest the most wanted man in the country.

New neighbors eventually moved in, and they seemed like nice people. But what do I know?

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AWARD HISTORY

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More information can be found about Whitey Bulger here:
https://themobmuseum.org/notable_names/whitey-bulger/

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